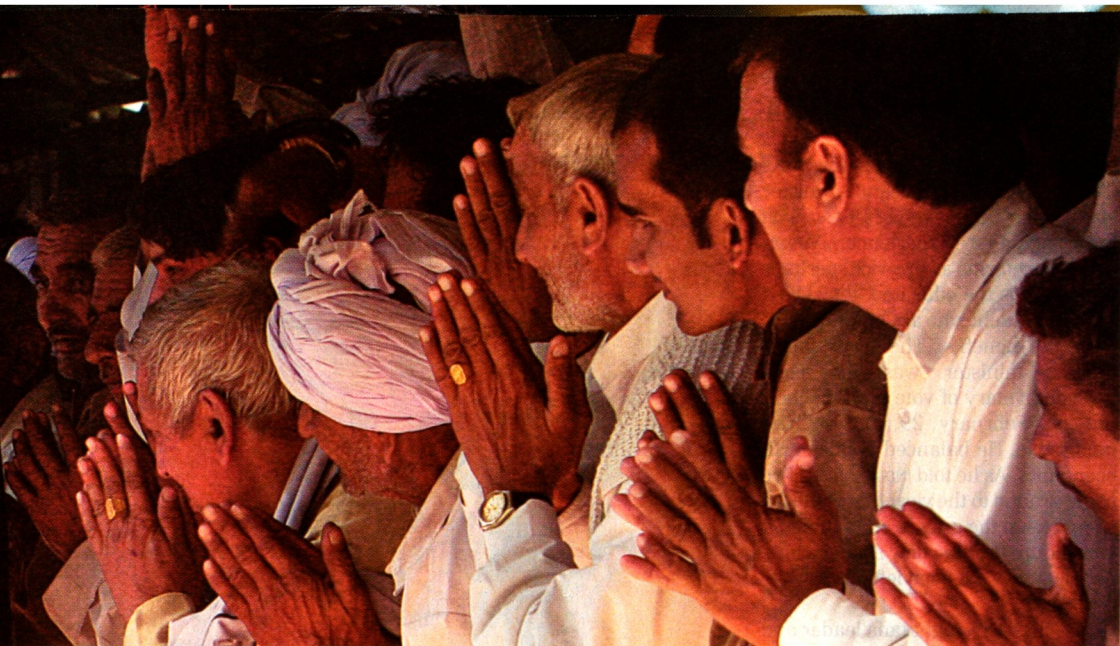




cover story SOP OPERA

NOW VOTE FOR US

Chidambaram's please-all Budget and a massive loan waiver for farmers sound the clarion call for UPA's campaign and ignite hopes of a revival and a return to power

■ By Priya Sahgal

It was perhaps a first for Palaniappan Chidambaram. He had a most unusual effect on Lok Sabha MPs last week. Minutes after he delivered his Budget speech, MPs across party lines were on the phone, cancelling weekend parties and making arrangements to head home. It was almost as if he had triggered an exodus. The Saturday after the Budget, most MPs left for their constituencies. They had read Chidambaram's lips. The 187-paragraph document was more a manifesto than a Budget. Like a magician, the Harvard-educated finance minister pulled rabbits out to appeal to every

voter listed on the electronic voting machine, from Dalits to Muslims and from the middle class to the farmer. Blamed by his party for inflation and electoral losses last year, Chidambaram is now turning out to be an unlikely mascot. As he unveiled the Rs 60,000-crore loan waiver, most MPs could see the Congress campaign unveil. The impact on the Opposition benches was best described by a Cabinet colleague who said, "*Saare zameen par* (everyone is floored)".

For almost 18 years, from the 1991 Narasimha Rao government to NDA's India Shining fiasco, political parties have struggled to communicate the benefits of